

ADVANCED HEPA FILTER AIR PURIFIER

New-gen purifiers with three-layer filtering—pre-filter, H13 HEPA filter and activated carbon filter—removing 99.9% of airborne particles

₹20,000–50,000

Impact: Expensive but keeps indoor air clean



CLEAN AIR IN A CAN

Bottled air from regions known for pristine air quality—Switzerland, Norway or Lake Como—now sold in cans

₹2,000-4,000

Impact: No proven effect on human health

SMART HELMET

Companies like Shellios Technolabs manufacture helmets that claim to cut pollutants by 80%

₹4,500

Impact: Effective in cutting exposure of bikers to pollutants



OXYGEN BAR

Companies like Oxypure and Oxybank allow customers to breathe pure oxygen for a fixed period



₹1,000–2,000

Impact: No proven benefit in countering air pollution effects

ANTI-POLLUTION PAINT

Some firms promote toxin-free indoor paints that eliminate harmful chemicals like formaldehyde

Price: Varies

Impact: Expensive but helps reduce indoor pollutants



HYPERBARIC OXYGEN THERAPY

HBOT is a medical treatment where patients breathe 100% oxygen in a pressurised chamber

Price: Varies

Impact: Only recommended for specific medical conditions

with claims that it counteracts pollution, improves sleep and boosts energy.

Dr Tarun Sahni, a senior consultant of internal medicine at Apollo Hospitals in Delhi and a pioneer in modern hyperbaric medicine in India, remains critical of the trend. "High-pressure oxygen is being touted for wellness and pollution relief, but these claims lack scientific backing," he says. "For any impact, you need medical-grade HBOT, which must be used for only 14 globally accepted treatments. Now, we have an entire [market of] off-label HBOT with uncertified equipment and doctors, [which could] do more harm than good...can cause respiratory distress to consumers and lead to explosions at the facility."

SO WHAT'S THE SOLUTION?

According to Dr Khanna of Manipal Hospital, pollution can affect an individual's health in two key ways: either high exposure for a short period or long-term low exposure. "It is impossible to quantify if breathing good-quality air for five per cent of your day is enough to counter the damage done the rest of the time. The best approach is to invest in a good mask and air purifier so that for as long as possible, you are breathing clean air," he says.



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DR ASHISH JAIN, *Director & Head, Respiratory Medicine, Pulmonology, Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket, Delhi*

Ultimately, the right to breathe clean air is a public health crisis that requires more than just individual solutions. "Pollution is not just a winter problem but a year-round hazard. Smog may be more visible in winter due to temperature inversion and seasonal emissions, but pollutants like nitrogen oxides, sulphur dioxide and fine particulate matter linger throughout the year," says Dr Ashish Jain, director and head, respiratory medicine, pulmonology, Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket, Delhi. The real solution, he argues, lies in systemic change. "Anti-pollution treatments are beneficial at an individual level to some extent only. They should be seen as complementary, rather than primary, solutions," he says.

That's because, while anti-pollution treatments may provide some relief, they cannot fully undo the damage caused by prolonged exposure to polluted air. Vulnerable groups, including those with lung conditions, children and the elderly, remain at risk even when air quality appears better. "Governments, communities and individuals must work together to eliminate pollution at its source by adopting clean energy, lowering emissions and promoting green spaces," says Dr Dosi. Only by addressing pollution at its root can we create a healthier environment for future generations. ■